

BEACH BARBECUE

Around 33 million people live in Oceania, with the vast majority of them residing in the towns and cities of coastal Australia and New Zealand. The Pacific islanders live on three main groups of islands—Micronesia, Melanesia, and Polynesia—and share similar languages and customs, although the vast distances between the islands make communication difficult and travel expensive.

Australia

A huge, mostly flat country, Australia largely consists of a vast, hot, inland desert, which is why nine-tenths of Australians live by the cooler coast. The Aborigines, Australia's first inhabitants, arrived from Asia 40,000 years ago. Europeans arrived in 1788 and now make up the overwhelming majority of the population.

Uluru / Ayers Rock

A massive outcrop of red sandstone carved by the wind and sandstorms, Uluru is considered a sacred site by the local Aborigines.

Canberra

Unable to choose between Sydney and Melbourne as Australia's capital city, it was decided to build a new capital—Canberra—midway between the two.

Aborigine culture

The Aborigines developed a sophisticated musical culture, based on a long bamboo or hardwood pipe that makes a deep, echoing sound—the didgeridoo.

Wildlife

Unique to the continent are kangaroos, koalas, black swans, plus the world's only egg-laying mammals—platypuses and echidnas.

Sydney

The largest and oldest city in Australia, Sydney lies around a large, sheltered harbor, with its iconic Opera House and world-famous Harbour Bridge.

